decision, for example, to make the party's rabble-rousing Gorakhpur MP Yogi Adityanath one of his star campaigners in UP has sent out a signal that saffron politics is an intrinsic part of the BJP's UP strategy. Western UP continues to simmer in the cauldron of religious polarization. The UP BJP wants to make an election issue of 'love jihad'—a dangerous term being used to suggest that Hindu–Muslim marriages are based on forced conversion. In Jammu and Kashmir, the call for a 'nationalist' government which will seek to abolish Article 370 is also disconcerting—politically sensitive issues cannot be settled in a cavalier manner. 'We are playing with fire,' warns a security official who has worked in the valley for years.

The apparent shift in strategy from the 'development driven' pattern to a sharper 'Hindutva' identity politics has already backfired in a series of by-elections since the general elections. The triumph in the 2014 general elections was driven by a recognition that the BJP needed to reinvent itself, adapt to a changing India by making governance and rapid growth its core issues, with Modi as the face of change. While the prime minister seems to have been astute enough to the embrace the new paradigm, some of the Sangh's foot soldiers seem a step behind. Unless, as some political observers suggest, the dualism of a prime minister who is striving to appear statesmanlike and a party leadership which is more ideologically rigid is part of a well-crafted double act by the Modi–Shah duo. Moreover, the BJP's decision to break ties with its twenty-five-year-old ally, the Shiv Sena in Maharashtra, only suggests that the duo are convinced that the mandate of 2014 was for a Modi-led BJP government, and not for an NDA-like coalition. Unilateralism, it seems, is the new mantra for the BJP leadership.

Modi and Shah, controversial but successful—easily the two stand-out politicians of 2014. Their rise will continue to attract sharply divided opinion. Modi, for example, will always be seen by his critics with a measure of scepticism. Eminent social scientist Ashis Nandy had written an article in the *Seminar* magazine in 2002, recalling an interview he had done with Modi as a pracharak in the early 1990s: 'It was a long, rambling interview but it left me in no doubt that here was a classical, clinical case of a fascist . . . all set within the matrix of clear paranoid and obsessive